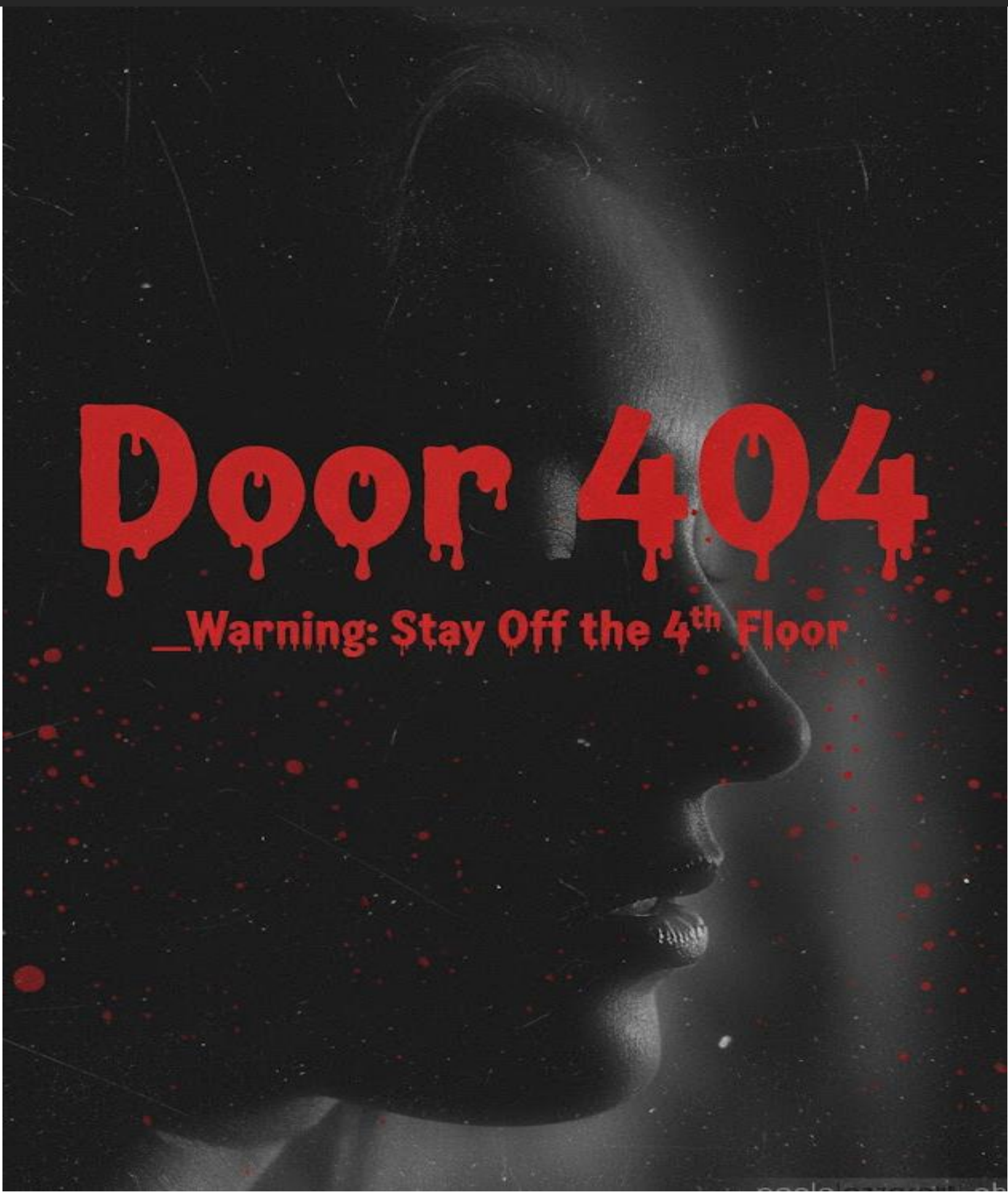

Door 404
_Warning: Stay Off the 4th Floor

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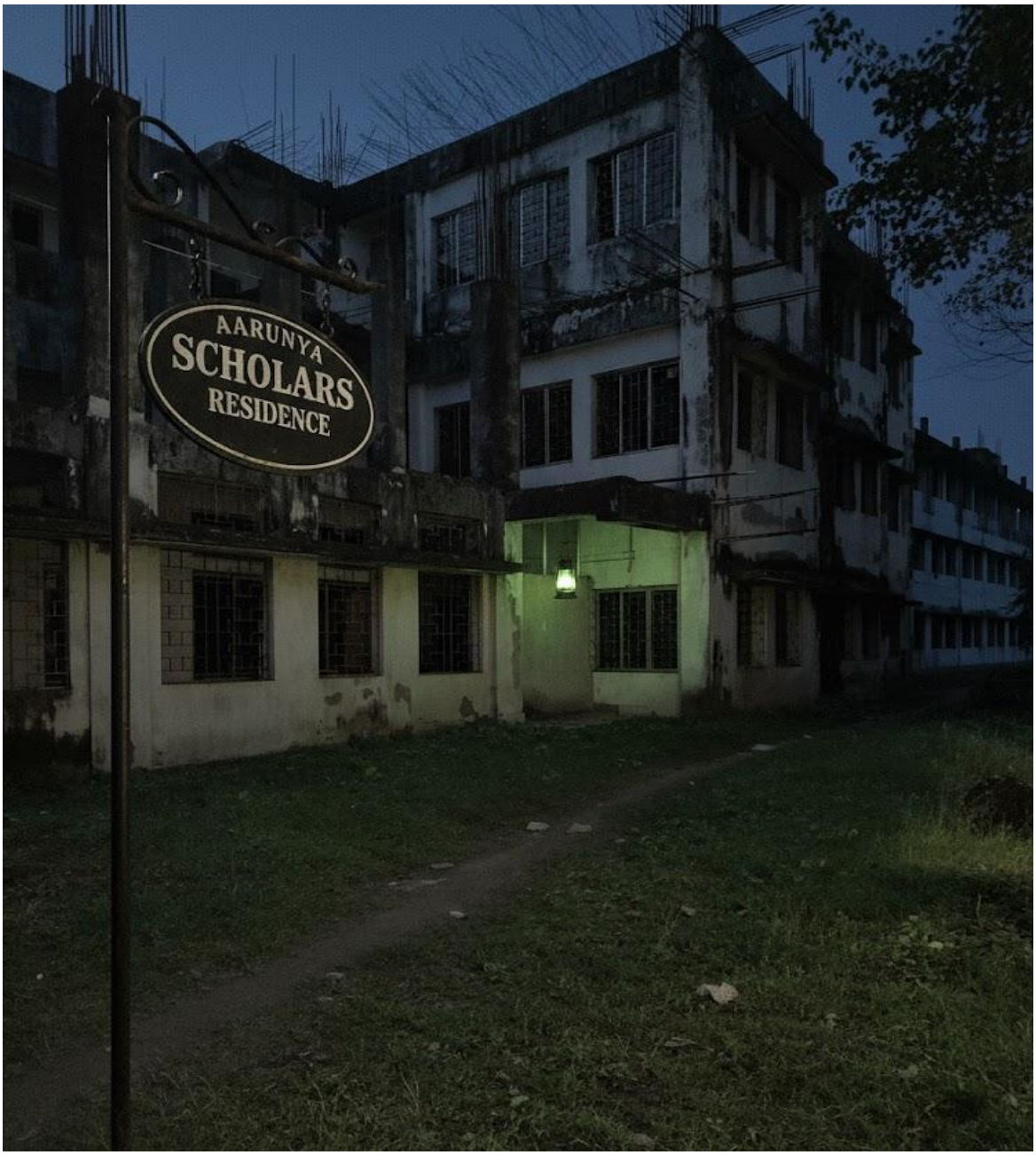
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[CHAPTER 1] - ARRIVAL AT AARUNYA



_warning: stay off the fourth flour

The monsoon rains poured relentlessly over Mangalore as Jishu's taxi wheezed along the narrow road leading to Aarunya Scholars' Residence. The hostel loomed ahead — a tall, cream-painted building, walls streaked with rain and time, standing like a sentinel over students' dreams… and nightmares.

Jishu clutched her duffel bag. Her heart was racing — not from fear, but anticipation. Two years of JEE prep awaited her here.

"Looks… older than I imagined," she murmured.

Inside, the warden, a thin woman with sharp eyes, gave her a clipboard. "Room 207, second floor. Lights out at 11. Study hall closes at 10. Any questions?"

"No… ma'am," Jishu said. But the warden's eyes lingered on her longer than necessary, a flicker of… warning?

In her room, two girls greeted her.

"I'm Avi! And that's Diya — last year's topper," one said brightly. "You'll love it here."

Diya, quiet and poised, just nodded, eyes scanning the corridor with an almost… wary expression.

Jishu placed her bag near the window. Outside, the rain-soaked courtyard shimmered under the dim lights. And somewhere in the building, she swore she heard a faint whisper — her name.

[CHAPTER 2] — THE MISSING FLOOR

The next evening, Jishu rode the elevator to the library and noticed something odd:

The buttons read: 1, 2, 3, 5, 6, Terrace.

No fourth floor.

“Where’s the fourth floor?” Jishu asked a senior standing next to her.

The senior froze, then smirked awkwardly. “Sealed off. Renovation years ago. Nothing interesting.”

“Strange,” Jishu muttered.

Later, during dinner:

“Do you know anything about the fourth floor?” she asked Diya and Avi.

Diya’s fork clattered. “Don’t ask about that,” she said, voice low.

“Why not?” Avi pressed.

“Because someone went there last year. Never came back,” Diya whispered. “Some say the warden called it a transfer. Others… heard screams.”

Thunder rumbled outside. Jishu laughed nervously. “Surely that’s just a rumor?”

Diya didn’t blink. “I wish it was.

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[CHAPTER 3] — THE WRITING ON THE WALL

Three nights later, at exactly 2:33 a.m., Jishu awoke to a scraping sound. Chalk against a wall.

Her heart thudded. She shone her phone's light across the room. Diya was sitting upright on floor, eyes closed, moving her hand in the air like writing on a chalkboard.

Jishu froze. "Diya?"

No response.

On the wall, faint letters appeared:

> "DON'T GO TO THE FOURTH FLOOR."

Diya murmured: "They're still studying… they never left…"

Jishu shook her awake. "Diya! Stop!"

Diya blinked, confused. The wall was blank again.

"You… you were writing," Jishu stammered.

Diya shook her head violently. "No. Stop. Forget it."

Jishu felt a chill brush her neck, like someone unseen was watching.

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[CHAPTER 4] — THE OLD RECORDS

The next evening, curiosity burned too bright. Jishu and Avi sneaked into the records room near the warden's office.

Inside, they found a dusty cabinet labeled: *Block C – Psychiatric Division 2007.*

"Psychiatric division?" Avi whispered.

"Yes," Jishu murmured. She opened files carefully. Patient logs, names, and experimental notes. And one page, written in red ink:

> Student 47: Repetitive mathematical scribbling during episodes. Claims 'the answers are on the fourth floor.'

A distant sound made them freeze. Click.

The warden's flashlight swept the room. She muttered, "I told you not to wake them… not again."

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[CHAPTER 5] — THE FOURTH FLOOR

That night, the girls couldn't resist. They crept past the study hall, found the iron staircase, and climbed.

At the top was a heavy metal door, chained and locked. A faint glow seeped through the cracks.

Jishu whispered, "This is it… the truth waits inside."

Avi swallowed hard. "Are we ready for it?"

Jishu found a rusted key hanging nearby. She unlocked the padlock. The door creaked open.

Inside, dust hung thick. The air smelled of old books and mold. Desks and chalkboards were scattered, filled with faded equations and notes. On one, the names of students long gone.

A file lay open. It detailed experiments on students — enhancing cognitive abilities at terrifying costs.

Whispers rose around them. Shadows flickered. Something moved at the edge of their vision.

Jishu's voice trembled. "We have to know… what really happened here."

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_warning: stay off the fourth flour

[CHAPTER 6] — A HIDDEN BUTTON

“The fourth floor’s been sealed for years,” the senior replied casually, as if mentioning the weather.

“Sealed?” Jishu frowned. “Why?”

The girl gave a faint, uneasy laugh. “Rumor says... it doesn’t exist anymore. After the accident.”

Before Jishu could ask further, the elevator dinged, and the senior quickly stepped out on the third floor, leaving behind a faint scent of lavender and mystery.

The doors closed again. The metallic hum filled the silence as the elevator ascended.

When it reached the fifth floor, Jishu hesitated before stepping out.

Something about that blank gap between ‘3’ and ‘5’ gnawed at her curiosity.
That night, Jishu , though slightly apprehensive, listened as her friend Avi animatedly recounted how they discovered the mysterious key. As she lay on her bed, Avi snoring softly beside her, the memory of the elevator buttons replayed in her mind.

There had to be a fourth floor — buildings didn’t just skip numbers.

Jishu sat up suddenly.

Maybe it was hidden behind a wall. Or accessible only through a service door.

She whispered to herself, “Tomorrow… I’ll find it.”

The next evening, she returned to the elevator alone.

The hostel was unusually quiet, the lights flickering like dying candles.

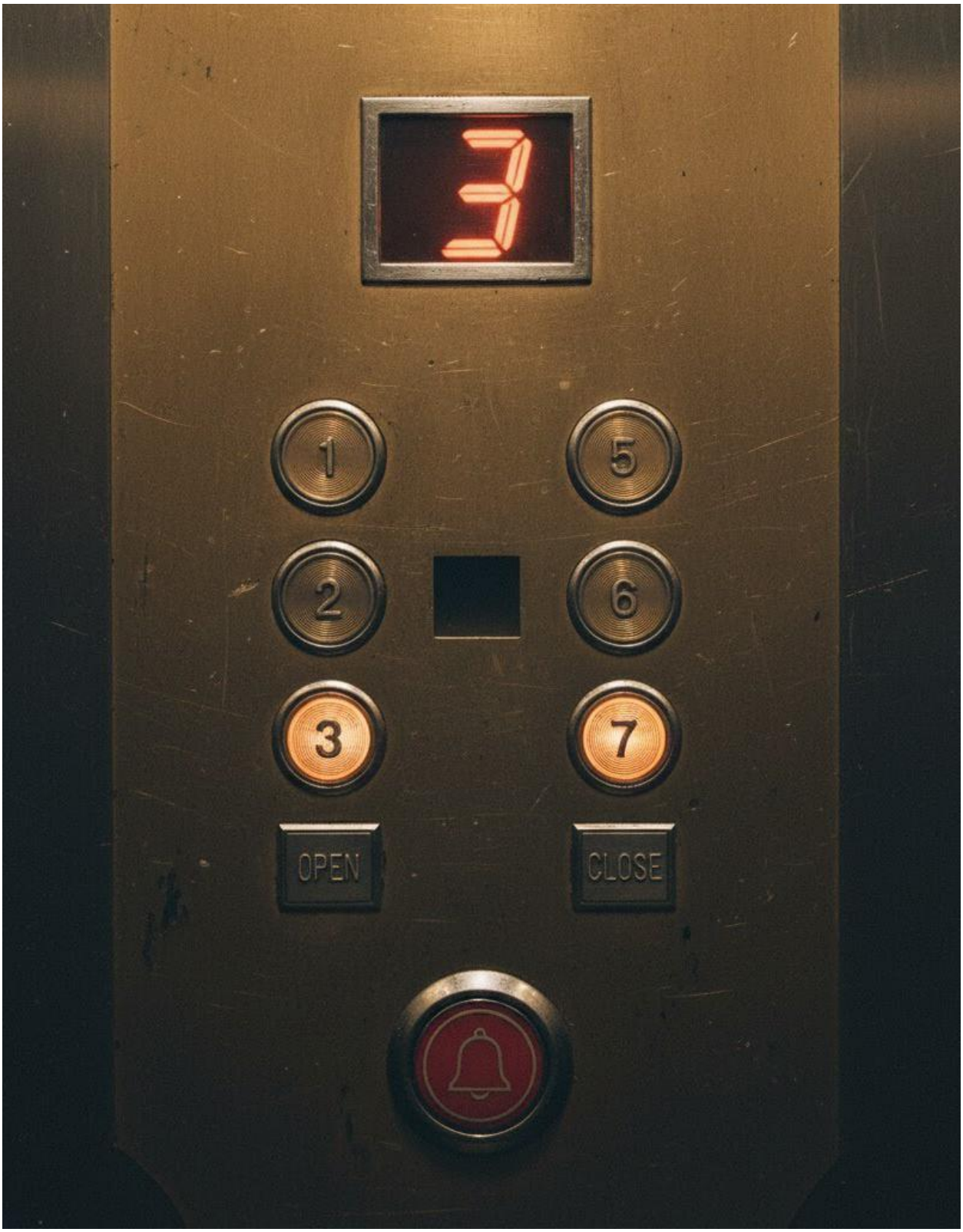
She ran her fingers over the buttons again ι — 1, 2, 3, 5, 6, Terrace.

But as her fingertip lingered between 3 and 5, she felt a small dent. A faint ridge.

A hidden button.

Her heart pounded. Slowly, she pressed it.

_warning: stay off the fourth flour



_warning: stay off the fourth flour

The lights inside the elevator dimmed.

The digital display flickered — 3... 4...

Then a soft ding.

The doors slid open.

A long, dimly lit corridor stretched ahead.

Dust floated through the air like fine mist. The faint smell of iron and mildew filled her nostrils.

She stepped out.

Behind her, the elevator doors shut — and the panel inside went dark.

For a moment, silence. Then she heard it — a soft scraping sound.

Like nails against concrete.

“Hello?” she whispered.

No response. Only the echo of her own voice… and then, faintly, a child’s giggle.

[CHAPTER 7] —THE CORRIDOR THAT BREATHES

The walls looked strange.

Not like the smooth, freshly painted ones of the other hostel floors. These were rough, cracked, and streaked with old brown stains that might've once been… blood.

The air was heavy — thick enough to feel against her skin.

Every step Jishu took echoed unnaturally long, as if the hallway itself were listening.

The fluorescent lights buzzed, some flickering weakly, others completely dead. Shadows stretched across the walls, bending in ways that didn't match her movement.

"Maybe this is… an old wing," she murmured, her voice trembling. "Just under maintenance."

But she knew she was lying to herself.

As she walked further, she noticed something odd — the same door number repeated every few feet:

Room 404. Room 404. Room 404.

Her breath quickened.

Every time she passed one, she marked it with her nail against the dusty wall. But when she looked back — the previous doors were gone.

It was the same hallway.

Repeating.

Endlessly.

She whispered, "This can't be real."

And then—

_warning: stay off the fourth flour

A soft knock echoed from one of the doors.

Knock. Knock. Knock.

Her hands trembled. She turned toward the sound. The handle moved slowly — not opening, just twitching, like someone was waiting inside.

“Who’s there?” she asked, her voice barely audible. The door creaked open an inch.

A low voice rasped, “You came back.” Jishu stumbled backward. “W-What?”

The door swung open violently. The room beyond was pitch-black.

Inside, a shadow stood — human-shaped but slightly distorted, as if the air around it was rippling. Jishu’s phone flashlight flickered, illuminating a wall full of scribbles.

Equations. Drawings. Dates. And one line written in thick, desperate strokes of red:

> "SHE NEVER LEFT."

The shadow tilted its head, whispering,

> “Do you remember Room 404, Jishu?”

Her heart stopped. How did it know her name? The air grew colder. Her breath came out in white clouds. She stumbled back toward the elevator, but when she turned the corner— It wasn’t there.

Only another hallway. Another set of Room 404 doors.

Suddenly, her phone buzzed. Avi (7:43 PM): Where are you? The warden’s asking for you. She said… no one should be on the fourth floor.

Jishu froze. Her hands shook as she typed: How do you know about the fourth floor?

Three dots appeared. Then a reply: Avi: Jishu… what fourth floor?

The phone slipped from her hand.

From the far end of the corridor, the shadow began to move — slow at first, then faster, its steps clicking sharply against the floor.

Jishu ran.



_warning: stay off the fourth flour

[CHAPTER 8] — THE WARDEN'S FILE

Jishu sprinted down the endless hallway, her shoes slapping against the cold tiles.

No matter how far she ran, the corridor kept stretching, repeating, mocking her.

Finally, she burst through a door — and stumbled into a stairwell.

Her chest heaved as she grabbed the rusty railing. The stairs spiraled upward into darkness.

She started climbing, but after just a few steps, she saw something carved into the wall — words etched deep, trembling and crooked:

> "STAIRS ALWAYS LED BACK."

Her pulse thundered in her ears. She kept climbing anyway. But when she reached the landing above, her breath hitched—

she was back where she started. Same floor. Same corridor.

Same faint smell of rust and something far rottener.

From the corner of her eye, she saw movement — a shadow slipping through a half-open door.

She followed, her hand trembling as she pushed it wider.

Inside was what looked like an office.

A decaying wooden desk, papers scattered across the floor, and a broken ceiling fan hanging by a thread. A nameplate lay among the dust:

"Warden – Mrs. Shalini Rao."

Jishu's throat tightened. The same warden who ran their hostel now.

She knelt and began reading the papers. The ink was faded, but the headings were clear:

"HOSTEL RESEARCH PROJECT – YEAR 2003."

“Cognitive Conditioning Through Sleep Frequency Alteration.”

Her eyes widened. They weren’t just running a hostel. They had been experimenting.

Another page caught her attention — a list of subjects. Twenty names.

And one of them, written in red ink, made her blood run cold:

> Subject 15 – JISHU A.

Her breath hitched. “No… that can’t be.”

A sound came from behind her — a slow, deliberate footstep.

Jishu turned.

The warden stood there, her eyes glassy, her face pale like wax.

“You weren’t supposed to find this, dear,” she said softly. “You were never supposed to remember.”

Jishu’s heart pounded. “What are you talking about?”

The warden took a step closer, her smile twitching. “The fourth floor was closed because you all… didn’t wake up.” Jishu stumbled back. “What do you mean— we didn’t wake up?”

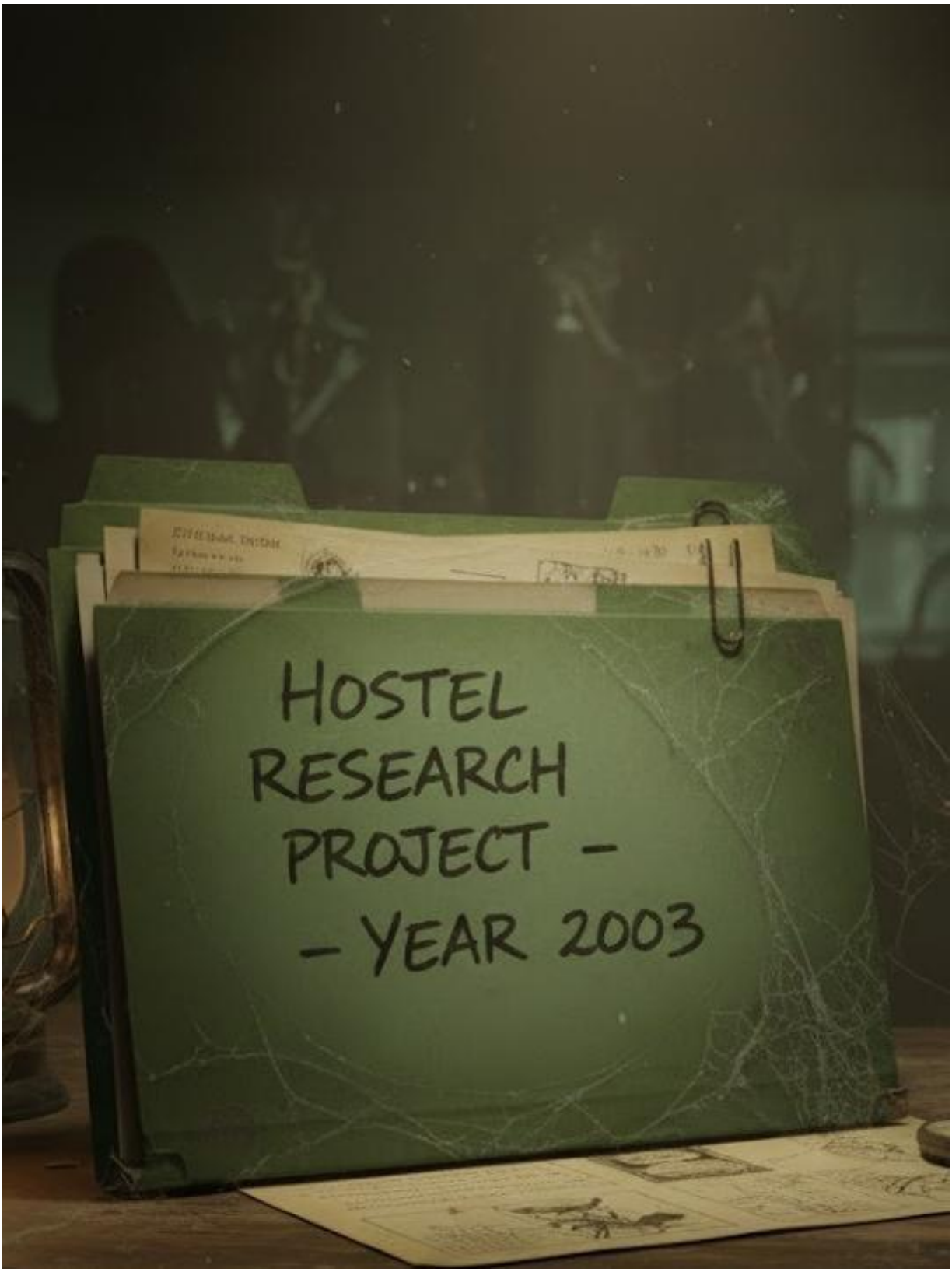
The warden’s eyes darkened. “This hostel isn’t real, Jishu. You’re still in the experiment.”

The room around her flickered. The walls began to breathe, expanding and contracting like lungs. The papers on the floor started floating.

And through the cracked glass of the window, she could see the outside world looping — the same people walking by again and again. Her phone buzzed once more.

Avi: Jishu, come back. We’re waiting. It’s almost time.

“Time for what?” Jishu whispered. The warden leaned closer, her voice now barely human. “For the next test.”



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[CHAPTER 9] — THE MEMORY THAT SHOULDN'T EXIST

The world was warping around Jishu.

The once-familiar hostel felt like it was melting—ceilings sagging, doors pulsing faintly like heartbeats. She pressed her palms against her temples, trying to breathe, but every inhale felt heavier than the last.

"None of this is real," she whispered. "None of this—"

"You said that last time too," a voice murmured behind her.

Jishu spun around. It was Avi.

Her best friend stood in the doorway, eyes wide but strangely distant.

"Avi!" Jishu gasped in relief. "We need to leave! The warden—she's—" "She's trying to help you," Avi interrupted softly. Jishu froze. "What are you saying?"

Avi stepped closer, her footsteps echoing unnaturally slow. "You were the first one they tested, Jishu. I tried to wake you up. But you never did."

Her voice cracked, the words trembling as if they carried years of grief.

"They kept your body alive, hooked to their machines in Room 404. You've been here… for fifteen years." The words hit like ice. Jishu's legs weakened. "No. That's not true—this is all real! You're real!"

Avi's eyes shimmered with something like sorrow. "I was. But not anymore."

The ground trembled beneath them. Light bulbs burst one by one. The air turned electric, thick with whispers. Jishu clutched her head, flashes hitting her mind like lightning —

— her lying on a hospital bed,

— white coats,

— wires connected to her temples, — a voice saying, “She’s still dreaming.”

Then darkness. When she opened her eyes again, the corridor was gone.

She was standing in Room 404. Rows of rusted hospital beds lined the walls. Each one held a motionless student; their faces covered in oxygen masks. The hum of machines filled the silence.

And there, in the last bed, was her. Her own body. Pale. Still. Eyes closed and the monitor beside it beeped steadily.

Jishu stumbled backward, shaking. “No. No, this can’t be—”

The door slammed shut behind her. The lights dimmed until only the reflection of her own sleeping face glowed faintly. And then, through the monitor’s screen, her reflection smiled.

> “We were never meant to wake up, Jishu.

Her reflection’s eyes opened — pitch black.

> “But maybe... this time, you will.”



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[CHAPTER 10] — THE AWAKENING

A steady beep. White light. The smell of disinfectant.

Jishu's eyes fluttered open.

A hospital ceiling stared back at her. She could feel something tight around her wrist and a soft hum of machines beside her bed.

She blinked, once, twice. Her throat was dry. "Avi…?" she whispered. No answer.

A nurse in white walked past the curtain. She gasped when she saw Jishu awake. "Doctor! She's conscious!"

Within seconds, a group of people rushed in — white coats, masks, clipboards. A man with kind eyes leaned over her. "Jishu, can you hear me?" She nodded weakly. "Where… am I?"

"You're in Karwar Research Hospital," he said softly. "You've been unconscious for a long time

Her head throbbed. "How long?" The doctors hesitated. "Fifteen years."

The world tilted. Jishu's heartbeat echoed in her ears. Fifteen years. That couldn't be. She was just in the hostel. She was just—

The doctor continued, "You were part of a project—something went wrong. You went into a prolonged dream state. But you're safe now. It's over."

Safe. The word felt wrong. Because as the doctor spoke, Jishu noticed something. The monitor beside her showed her heart rate — but its rhythm was off.

Every fourth beep stuttered. Almost like a whisper.

4... 4... 4...

Her stomach twisted. "Why does it keep saying four?"

The nurse blinked. "What are you talking about?"

"It's right there! The beeping—it's saying four!"

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The doctor exchanged a glance with the nurse. “There’s no sound pattern, Miss Jishu. Just normal vitals.”

But Jishu heard it again, clear this time — through the beeping, a faint child’s giggle.

Her blood ran cold.

“No…” she whispered. “It followed me.”

The lights flickered once. The air monitor clicked.

And for a split second, the reflection in the steel cabinet beside her bed smiled — not the weak, tired smile she had now, but the dark, knowing grin of her reflection from Room 404.

She screamed.

The staff rushed forward, trying to calm her, but their voices blurred, drowned by that rhythmic hum.

The lights flickered faster, like the pulse of a living thing. Then, suddenly, the power cut.

Darkness.

Only the glow of the monitor remained, beeping rhythmically—

1 … 2 … 3 … 5 … 6 … TERRACE.

Her breath hitched.

The buttons.

The missing floor.

And from somewhere deep inside the room, a familiar, warm voice whispered:

> “Welcome back, Jishu.”

[CHAPTER 11] — THE SECOND LAYER

The darkness wasn't complete — faint light flickered through the blinds.

Outside, rain lashed against the window like fingers tapping, begging to be let in.

Jishu sat upright, her heart pounding. The machines around her had stopped, yet the beeping continued — soft, rhythmic, echoing inside her skull.

> 1... 2... 3... 5... 6... Terrace.

Her breath came shallow. It's not over, she thought. — the pain was sharp, grounding. The scent of blood mixed with antiseptic. She swung her legs off the bed and stepped down onto the cold tiles.

For the first time, she noticed — the door to her ward didn't have a number.

Only a faint shadow where one used to be. Her fingers brushed the surface. Dust came off, revealing faded letters beneath:

"WARD 404."

Her pulse spiked. "No. Not again—"

Before she could step back, the lights flickered, and the door clicked open.

A man in a patient gown stood there, pale and trembling.

He looked about her age, maybe slightly older — dark eyes, messy hair. But there was something achingly familiar about him. "You're awake too," he said quietly. Jishu frowned.

"Who are you?" He hesitated before answering. "Manik. Subject 14." She froze. "Subject...?"

He nodded slowly. “I was in the room next to yours — fifteen years ago. We were the only ones who stayed conscious during the first collapse. I’ve been waking up... over and over again.”

Jishu stepped closer. “What do you mean, over and over?”

Manik’s gaze was hollow. “Every time I think I wake up, I find another layer. Different walls. Different doctors. Same experiment. It never ends.”

She shook her head. “No. That’s not true. The doctor said it’s over.”

Manik’s voice dropped to a whisper. “That’s what they always say. Until you see it again.”

He stepped aside and pointed down the corridor.

The fluorescent lights there flickered in an odd pattern — one by one, skipping a section in the middle.

1…2….3….

…blank…

5....6……

TERRACE.

Jishu’s stomach twisted. Manik turned back to her. “You felt it, didn’t you? The missing fourth floor. It’s still here — just buried deeper. Every time they pull us out, they rewrite the world. But the cracks remain. “He glanced around nervously. “The fourth layer is waking again.”

A cold gust blew down the hall, carrying a faint, mechanical hum — the sound of elevators moving through invisible shafts. And then a voice came through the hospital intercom — soft, crackling, female.

> “Attention all staff. Subject 15 has regained awareness.” ’

Jishu froze. The intercom repeated, now more distorted:

> “Subject 15 has remembered.”'

Manik grabbed her hand. “We need to go. Now.”

They ran. Through the endless white corridors, past empty nurse stations, past windows that showed no outside world — only static. Behind them, the walls began to ripple. The white paint peeled off, revealing cracked grey concrete underneath — the same walls from the hostel’s fourth floor. The illusion was fading. Jishu stopped, gasping. “Manik... if this isn’t real, then where is the real world?” He looked at her, eyes burning with something fierce and tired.

> “That’s what they don’t want us to find.

The lights above them burst, showering sparks. From the far end of the corridor, a shadow moved — smooth, deliberate, whispering as it came.

And faintly, through the noise, Jishu heard the warden’s voice again, layered with static:

> “Test 2 — Cognitive Awakening. Proceed to next cycle.”

Everything shook. The floor cracked open beneath them.

And then—

Silence.

[CHAPTER 12] — THE IN-BETWEEN

When the floor gave way, Jishu felt the world shatter beneath her. She fell through darkness — endless, heavy, silent. Then, suddenly, she landed on cold ground. The air around her was thick with fog. Dim lights flickered overhead — one moment hospital tubes, the next hostel lamps. The world was melting together — part ward, part dormitory, part dream. Beside her, Manik groaned, pulling himself up. “We made it,” he said, though his voice trembled.

Jishu looked around. The walls were covered with old photos of students — smiling faces, name tags, hostel uniforms. But their eyes had been scratched out. And in the center of the floor stood the elevator. Its doors open. Waiting.

The buttons inside glowed faintly.

1, 2, 3, 5, 6, TERRACE...

And beneath them, a new one had appeared — pulsing dimly red. REALITY.

Jishu whispered, “Maybe that’s it. Maybe it takes us out.” Manik didn’t answer immediately. His eyes were on the ceiling. “Every time I pressed that button... I woke up somewhere new. But never free.” Jishu turned to him, desperate. “Then what do we do? Stay here forever?”

He looked at her, the faintest smile on his face. “Maybe it’s not about escaping. Maybe it’s about remembering.” “Remembering what?”

He pointed toward the wall — where the photographs had begun to shift, the scratched-out faces now reforming. One photo stood out — two teenagers standing side by side in hostel uniforms. Jishu. And Manik. She staggered closer. The back of the photo was scribbled with a note, her own handwriting:

> If we forget, we repeat. If we remember, we rest.

Her throat tightened. “So that’s why it kept looping… because we forgot.” Manik nodded. “They used us to study how memory rewrites pain. But if we remember everything — the fear, the truth, the past — the cycle ends. “Jishu closed her eyes. The memories flooded back —

The experiments. The dreams. The screams from the fourth floor. Avi’s smile before everything went dark. Tears ran down her cheeks. “I remember.”

The world began to tremble. The elevator lights flickered violently. The red REALITY button glowed brighter — like it was waiting for her touch.

Manik reached for her hand. “Together this time?”

She nodded. They stepped into the elevator.

The doors slid shut. The sound was final — like the last page of a story turning. The numbers blinked in sequence —

1... 2... 3... 4. For the first time, 4 appeared. The missing floor had returned.

The elevator shook, the light turned blinding white, and a deep voice — familiar, soft, peaceful — whispered:

> “You’ve reached the end, Jishu.”

When she opened her eyes again, she was standing under a sunrise. Outside the hostel gates. The air smelled of rain. Birds chirped. Students laughed nearby. The world was normal.

She turned to her side — but Manik was gone. Only his bracelet lay in the grass, the tag faintly etched with “Subject 14.” Jishu smiled sadly. She looked up at the old building.

The elevator door on the terrace opened once — just slightly — as if saying goodbye. Then silence. She whispered, “We remembered. “And somewhere deep inside the walls of that hostel —the echo of a voice whispered back,

> “And now, we rest.”

_warning: stay off the fourth flour



_warning: stay off the fourth flour

ABOUT

The door 404 is a spine-chilling journey into mystery and horror. As you turn the pages you will uncover the secrets lurking behind the door 404, where reality blurs.

Be warned: this is not a fairy tale.

ABOUT THE AUTHORS:

Inchara and Manjusha (students of MSRIT) have poured their creativity and passion into crafting this gripping novel.

Stay tuned for more spine-tingling adventures!!